

SCHOOL COUNSELING SERVICES - ELEMENTARY, MIDDLE, AND HIGH SCHOOLS

The Loudoun County Public Schools (LCPS) School Counseling Program assists students' development in academic, career, and personal/social areas through the school counseling curriculum, individual student planning and counseling, responsive services and systems supports.

Each school shall establish a data-driven process for determining the specific counseling needs of students and for planning how to effectively meet those needs. School counseling shall be provided for all students and shall be designed in accordance to the Standards for School Counseling Programs in Virginia Public Schools.

A. School Counseling Services. Each school provides the following guidance and counseling services to all students:

1. Academic guidance which assists students and their parents to acquire knowledge of the curricula choices available to students, to plan a program of studies, to arrange and interpret academic testing and to seek post-secondary academic opportunities;
2. Career guidance which helps students to acquire information and plan action about work, jobs, apprenticeships, and post-secondary educational and career opportunities;
3. Personal/social counseling which assists a student to develop an understanding of themselves, the rights and needs of others, how to resolve conflict, how to define individual goals that reflect their interests, abilities, and aptitudes. Such counseling may be provided either: (i) in groups (e.g., all fifth graders) in which generic issues of social development is addressed; or (ii) through structured individual or small group multi-session counseling which focuses on the specific concerns of the student participants (e.g., stress management, impulse control, emotional regulation, etc.). Personal/social counseling includes services delivered by school counselors to students, either individually or in groups, and includes character education and bullying prevention. Personal/social counseling does not include social-emotional learning lessons provided by teachers and other instructional staff; and

The counseling techniques employed by LCPS do not include the use of counseling techniques which are beyond the scope of the professional certification or training of counselors, including hypnosis, or other psychotherapeutic techniques that are normally employed in medical or clinical settings and focus on mental illness or psychopathology.

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B. Employment Counseling and Placement Services. LCPS provides to secondary students employment counseling and placement services to furnish information relating to the employment opportunities available to students graduating from or leaving the schools within LCPS. Such information includes all types of employment opportunities, including, but not limited to, apprenticeships, the military, career education schools and the teaching profession. In providing such services, LCPS consults and cooperates with the Virginia Employment Commission, the Department of Labor and Industry, local business and labor organizations and career schools. If LCPS provides access to one or more of its high schools and contact with such high school's student body or other contact with its high school students during a school or school division-sponsored activity to persons or groups for occupational, professional or educational recruitment, it provides equal access on the same basis to official recruiting representatives of the military forces of the Commonwealth and the United States.

C. Parental Notification of Counseling Programs and Student Participation

1. Parents/guardians are notified annually about the counseling programs which are available to their children. The notification shall include the purpose and general description of the programs, information regarding ways parents/guardians may review the materials to be used in counseling programs at their child's school, and information about the procedures by which parents/guardians may limit their child's participation in such programs.

2. School counseling program materials shall be made available at each school for review. Any interested parent/guardian seeking to review such counseling program materials may contact the school counselor.

3. Parents may elect, by notifying their child's school in writing, to have their child opt out of participation in personal/social counseling. Parental consent is not required for short-duration personal/social counseling, which is needed to maintain order, discipline, or a productive learning environment.

4. No student is required to participate in any counseling program to which the student's parents/guardians object.

D. Confidentiality of Counseling Information and Records. Information and records of personal/social counseling will be kept confidential and separate from a student's educational records and not disclosed to third parties without prior parental consent or as otherwise provided by law.

E. Public Participation Prior to Amendments Hereto. Before adopting any amendment to this policy, the School Board shall provide for public participation and comment.

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[Former Policy 5-6]
Revised: 5/28/96, 8/14/18
Current Revision: 4/25/23

Leg Refs: [8 VAC 20-620-10](#), School Guidance and Services; Va. Code §§ [22.1-253.13:1](#)
et seq. and [22.1-208.01](#) Character Education Required